the system lacked mechanisms to identify and correct these errors. The democratic way of distributing information – and the power to make decisions – between many institutions and individuals worked better. It could cope far more efficiently with the flood of data, and if one institution made a wrong decision, it could eventually be rectified by others.

The rise of machine-learning algorithms, however, may be exactly what the Stalins of the world have been waiting for. AI could tilt the technological balance of power in favour of totalitarianism. Indeed, whereas flooding people with data tends to overwhelm them and therefore leads to errors, flooding AI with data tends to make it more efficient. Consequently, AI seems to favour the concentration of information and decision-making in one place.

Even in democratic countries, a few corporations like Google, Facebook and Amazon have become monopolies in their domains, partly because AI tips the balance in favour of the giants. In traditional industries like restaurants, size isn't an overwhelming advantage. McDonald's is a worldwide chain that feeds more than fifty million people a day,[3] and its size gives it many advantages in terms of costs, branding and so forth. You can nevertheless open a neighbourhood restaurant that could hold its own against the local McDonald's. Even though your restaurant might be serving just two hundred customers a day, you still have a chance of making better food than McDonald's and gaining the loyalty of happier customers.

It works differently in the information market. The Google search engine is used every day by between two and three billion people making 8.5 billion searches.[4] Suppose a local start-up search engine tries to compete with Google. It doesn't stand a chance. Because Google is already used by billions, it has so much more data at its disposal that it can train far better algorithms, which will attract even more traffic, which will be used to train the next generation of algorithms, and so on. Consequently, in 2023 Google controlled 91.5 per cent of the global search market.[5]

Or consider genetics. Suppose several companies in different countries try to develop an algorithm that identifies connections between genes and medical conditions. New Zealand has a population of 5 million people, and privacy regulations restrict access to their genetic and medical records. China has about 1.4 billion inhabitants and laxer privacy regulations.[6] Who do you think has a better chance of developing a genetic algorithm? If